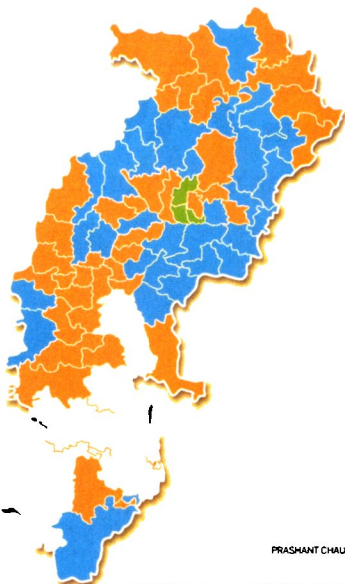




ASSEMBLY
Elections 08

Photographs by VINAY SHARMA

CHHATTISGARH ASSEMBLY POLL 08



PRASHANT CHAUDHARY

RESULT	2008	2003
■ BJP	50	50
■ CONG	38	37
■ BSP	2	2

* Total number of seats: 90

6.13%

was the vote
share of the BSP
in these assem-
bly elections

19

is the number of
the Scheduled
Tribe seats won
by the BJP

12

is the number of
seats by which
the BJP outshone
the Congress



**Jogi drew an inevitable comparison
with Singh. For him, this was perhaps
the last shot at power in Chhattisgarh.**

of seats—it won two just like 2003. The modest rise in its share at the cost of Congress's traditional Satnami Dalit community vote, concentrated in the Central plains of Chhattisgarh, did enough to nix the Congress's hopes.

If the consistent erosion of its traditional vote to the BSP put paid to the Congress's hopes, the BJP too had its share of troubles in the run-up to the polls. Speaker in the outgoing assembly Premprakash Pandey is believed to have lost the election from Bhilai on account of the local versus outsider issue raised by Durg MP Tarachand Sahu. In a State where tribal sentiments are never far away from boiling over, such divisive trends, especially when violent incidents have happened in the past involving Haryanvi and Bihari settlers, could hurt the BJP in the future as it has sizeable support among these communities.

Locally, Sahus and Kurmis are the most numerous and voluble obc groups and the latter, led by Raipur MP Ramesh Bais, have already aired their grievances in the past. Singh will have to deploy all his political nous and be at his conciliatory best to bring the grumbling sections together. An indulgent high command and a hugely popular

foodgrains scheme can only go so far.

For Jogi who is on the wrong side of 60, it was perhaps his last realistic shot at power in Chhattisgarh. A self-confessed autocrat, a wily Jogi didn't allow any other power centre to gain a toe-hold in the Congress even when he was kept away from the thick of the action. The party could now pay a heavy price for it. Among the younger lot, the party neither has a saleable name nor does it have a tribal leader in a state which has almost 32 per cent tribal population, nor does it have creditable Dalit leadership. The two communities once formed the bedrock of the Congress's support base.

The party hasn't helped its own cause by machinations behind closed doors. It could not allow Jogi a free run despite his undisputed status as the party's numero uno leader in the state because he had led the party to defeat as also because of his son's alleged involvement in a murder case. To make matters worse, it adopted a revolving-door policy for the PCC president's post. Yet, the Congress held its own in a tough contest, indicating the party's inherent strength at the grassroots. That is something that the party can build upon. For Singh, it is a wake-up call that future electoral battles won't be easy either. ■